



Gong Playing Workshop

*with Martina Reinbold &
the Udara Sound Healing Team*

Workshop Overview

This 3-hour Gong Playing Workshop offers an interactive learning experience, delving into the principles of sound healing, the rich history and diverse types of gongs, and practical techniques for playing them with various types of mallets. You will explore the profound connection between sound, vibration, intuition, intention and presence, fostering a space of transformation and healing for yourself and others.

What is Sound Healing and how does it work?

Sound healing is the specific use of frequencies to promote healing and balance. Sound can have profound effects on our health and well-being, whether we actively listen to music, play an instrument, move to the beat of the music, or receive beneficial frequencies in a passive way.

It addresses various planes of our existence, from the physical to the emotional and spiritual levels, by using different instruments and the voice. In a way, it helps us to be more "in tune" with ourselves and "in sync" with the natural laws, structure, and order of the cosmos.

In general, sound healing therapy is based on the principle that all of life is vibration, including our own bodies. When our resonant frequency is out of balance, our physical and emotional health can be affected.

"Each celestial body, in fact each and every atom, produces a particular sound on account of its movement, its rhythm or vibration. All these sounds and vibrations form a universal harmony in which each element, while having its own function and character, contributes to the whole."

Pythagoras (569-475 BC)

Everything is Vibration

Modern quantum physics and ancient traditions agree that everything is in a state of vibration. Sound precedes light, and the universe began with the power of vibration. Using sound for healing is based on the principle that every part of our body is in a state of vibration, and restoring balance to those vibrations can promote well-being.

Einstein said: *"Everything is energy, and that's all there is to it. Match the frequency of the reality you want, and you cannot help but get that reality. It can be no other way. This is not philosophy. This is physics."*

Since the rise of quantum physics, which aims to explain the model of reality and existence from the micro to the macrocosm, we have been experiencing a significant paradigm shift. The previous split between spirituality and science—the disconnection of body and mind—seems to be slowly dissolving. It is being replaced not only by a belief but also by scientific evidence that everything and everyone is interconnected in a sea of vibration.

These profound insights from ancient philosophy and modern physics underscore the fundamental principle of sound healing: that by harmonizing our internal vibrations, we can achieve greater well-being.

The Power of Intention

The combination of frequency (sound) and intent (thoughts) plays a crucial role in healing. Sound healing pioneer Jonathan Goldman developed the formula:

Frequency + Intention = Healing

The sound healing experience is always a combination of various elements coming together: the player, the instrument, the receiver, the space, and the intention behind the sound. Each day and each session creates a unique journey. While frequency provides the vibrational input, intention acts as a guiding force, directing and amplifying the healing potential. By focusing our thoughts and desires, we can consciously participate in the process of restoring balance and promoting well-being.

The Benefits of Sound Healing

Sound is known as one of the most natural forms of healing known to mankind. Some cultures have long realised that the beneficial effects of sound go much deeper than just relaxation. Sound healing touches us on so many different levels: physical, energetic, emotional, mental and spiritual.

The potential positive effects of Sound Healing may include:

- stress reduction
- emotional balance
- lowered blood pressure
- soothing the nervous system
- improved sleep
- muscle relaxation
- more coherence in the brain waves
- deepening meditative states, calming the mind

GONGS

Traditionally, Gongs belong to the percussion family. They can have a determined pitch or undefined frequencies. Gongs come in a variety of types, sizes, shapes and styles, each with its own unique sound characteristics and cultural significance.

Examples of Different Types of Gongs

- **Chinese Chau Gongs:** Also known as Tam-Tam gongs, Chau gongs are large, flat gongs with a turned-down rim.
- **Feng or Wind Gongs:** Flat gongs or with a slightly convex surface and taper towards the edges
- **Paiste Gongs:** These are modern gongs manufactured by the German Paiste company. They come in various sizes and styles, including Symphonic and Planetary gongs.
- **Balinese and Javanese Gamelan Gongs:** In the gamelan ensembles of Indonesia, gongs play a central role in art and ceremony. The gongs come in various sizes, each with its own pitch and role within the ensemble. These gongs usually have a **nipple** in the centre.

How Gongs are made

Gongs are crafted from hammered metal, primarily an alloy of copper and tin (bronze) or brass, often combined with other metals. The manufacturing process begins by melting the metal and casting it into sheets of varying thicknesses. These sheets are then meticulously cut and shaped, with the contours and outer design carefully formed. Through a combination of hand hammering and mechanical techniques, the gong's surface is shaped, and its unique tonal qualities are developed by adjusting its thickness.

The form and sound are further refined through rim turning and tempering. For its final appearance, the gong's surface can be treated, for instance, by engraving mandalas or mantra scriptures. Finally, a string is attached through two holes, allowing the gong to be suspended on a wooden or metal stand, or held by the player if its size and weight permit portability.

History of Gongs

The gong is one of the most ancient musical instruments worldwide, with archaeological discoveries unearthing gongs constructed almost four thousand years ago. The earliest written mention of gongs dates back to China in the 6th century. In China, gongs served multiple ceremonial roles, resonating to signal the arrival of significant figures such as the emperor and played a vital role in military gatherings for battle preparations.

This musical tradition then traversed from China to Java, and the term "gong" itself is Javanese language. By the 9th century, the gong was well-established in Indonesia. The Javanese crafted their gongs in a unique way with deep, turned-down rims and a raised central knob (=nipple). The Indonesians also pioneered the ensemble practice of playing multiple gongs concurrently, forming a percussion orchestra known as a gamelan.

From Asia, gongs gradually journeyed to Africa and eventually reached Europe during the 18th century. In Europe, the first style of gong encountered was the Chinese gong with indefinite pitch, nowadays often situated at the rear of orchestras. It was Georges Bizet who initially introduced the gong into a musical composition in his opera "Carmen."

From ancient ceremonies to modern orchestras and healing practices, the gong continues its powerful legacy, inviting us to connect with its profound resonance.

How to play Gongs

Gongs are versatile instruments, as they can be played with different **mallets** to produce a wide range of sounds.

- e-Mallets
- Flumis (Ball mallets)
- Shamanic drum / timpani mallets
- Gong mallet (e.g. Paiste mallet)

There are many **techniques on how** to play gongs, creating different frequencies, intensities and dynamics. Here are a few examples:

- Whale sounds with e-Mallets
- Stroking the surface with one or two e-mallets or flumi mallets
- Find drone sounds with flumi mallets (one continuous, distinct note)
- Drumroll with two mallets
- Heartbeat
- Tapping the clock (using different areas of the gong like 11,12,1 or 5,6,7 o'clock)
- Rhythmic playing
- Drone (continuous sound)
- Waves (increasing and decreasing volume like an ocean wave)
- Single strokes

Your Relationship with Sound - Listen, Feel & Play

Playing the gong can open a profound and transformative path of self-discovery. Beyond simply receiving sound healing through group journeys or individual sessions, learning to play the gong allows you to deeply connect with its unique resonance, creating a personal relationship with the powerful vibrations it offers.

As you explore the gong, you'll discover how its sounds and vibrations interact with the different layers of your being—physical, emotional, mental, energetic, and spiritual. The act of playing invites you to listen consciously—not just with your ears, but with your entire body—and to feel the gong's vibrations both within you and in the surrounding energy field.

Playing the gong also allows for a deeper appreciation of its cultural roots, connecting you to traditions where sound has been used as a tool for healing and transformation across generations.

Through intuitive and creative expression, the gong teaches us to embrace a wide spectrum of sounds, from the harmonious to the discordant. This practice can help us create greater balance and attunement in our lives—both with ourselves and with the world around us. By exploring how we play and respond to sound, we may also uncover insights into how we relate to others, to nature, and to the universe as a whole.

Every strike on the gong invites you to listen, feel, and connect. It's a reminder that sound is not just heard—it is experienced with your whole body as a sensory organ.

Sound Reflections

- What feelings arise when you play the gong?
- How does its sound resonate within your body and in the space around you?
- Are there tones or frequencies you are drawn to? Or ones you avoid?
- Do you play the gong or does the gong want to be played in a certain way?

The Polarizing Power of Gongs: Sensitivity in Sound Healing

Gongs are powerful instruments that can evoke a wide spectrum of responses, making them uniquely polarizing in sound healing sessions. During a gong sound bath, some participants may feel a deep sense of relaxation, love the immersive vibrations, and experience profound transformation or emotional release. For others, the intense resonance of the gong can feel overwhelming, triggering a sensitive nervous system, or even evoking fear or discomfort.

These diverse reactions stem from the gong's ability to access deep layers of the subconscious and energy body, touching unprocessed emotions or memories. As such, gong players must approach their craft with sensitivity and awareness, holding a safe and supportive space for participants. By attuning to the group's energy and being mindful of the gong's dynamic range, players can help guide the experience with intention and care, ensuring that even challenging moments can lead to integration and healing.

Beyond the Workshop: Your Personal Gong Journey

Gong playing can be seamlessly integrated into daily life as a personal meditation practice, fostering mindfulness and emotional as well as energetic balance. Within sound healing, it serves as a powerful tool for transformation and energetic realignment, either in individual sessions or group sound baths. Furthermore, the resonant vibrations of the gong can beautifully complement other healing modalities such as yoga, reiki, or massage, enhancing their therapeutic effects and creating a more holistic experience.

As you conclude this workshop, remember that your journey with the gong is just beginning. We encourage you to acquire your own gong, take the time to truly get to know it, and form a unique relationship with this powerful instrument. Explore playing for yourself, notice the profound effects it has on your well-being, and share its vibrations with friends and family. Don't hesitate to ask for feedback as you grow, and most importantly, enjoy the powerful and transformative vibrations that the gong offers.